

MOJAVE DESERT

The smallest and driest desert in the US

The Mojave Desert covers 25,000 sq miles (65,000 sq km) of alternating mountain ranges and flat, low-lying basins, mainly in southern California. The Mojave merges almost imperceptibly with the Sonoran Desert to the south and the Great Basin Desert to the north. Its extent is traditionally indicated by the range of an endemic yucca, the Joshua tree (see main photo). This distinctive plant is one of more than 200 found only in the Mojave, which make up a quarter of the desert's plant species.

Land of extremes

The Mojave Desert is dry because it lies in the rain shadow of the Rocky Mountains. It is a high desert, lying mostly at more than 1,970 ft (600 m) above sea level. Daytime temperatures are high, nowhere more so than

in Death Valley in the north, where at Furnace Creek on July 10, 1913, the atmospheric temperature reached 134°F (56.7°C), the highest ever recorded on Earth. Death Valley also holds the record for the lowest place in the US: Badwater Basin dips to 282 ft (86 m) below sea level. The name refers to a small spring, whose waters contain high levels of dissolved salts, making them undrinkable for humans. However, the spring does support other life, including pickleweed, a variety of aquatic insects, and the Badwater snail, another Mojave endemic. Other desert specialists living in the Mojave include the kangaroo rat, the desert tortoise, and the deadly Mojave rattlesnake.



DESERT BLOOM

Many desert plants are able to remain dormant for years, until sufficient rain falls for them to grow, flower, and set seed. Antelope Valley in the western tip of the desert is famous for the poppies and other flowers that bloom following the winter rains.

MOJAVE GROUND SQUIRREL

BIDDING THEIR TIME

Mojave ground squirrels survive droughts by not breeding and extending a form of dormancy known as estivation to eke out scarce food resources. Even so, populations frequently crash, but their numbers recover rapidly once the rains return.

The hottest place in North America

Average annual

CALIFORNIA POPPIES

More than 200 endemic plants

YUCCA MOTH

MUTUAL BENEFIT

The yucca moth is named for the plant that depends on it for survival. Females lay eggs in yucca flowers, then pollinate them by forcing pollen into the stigma. When the larvae hatch, they eat some of the developing seeds but the rest is left to grow.